

Why Do Customers Turn Off Autopay? — Walkthrough Script

Task 5 Update — plain English throughout

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Plain-English Summary

We wanted to know the real reasons customers turn off autopay, because the team believed 38% of removals came from new customers backing out early. We pulled every autopay removal from the last 6 months, split them into online (self-service) versus phone-call removals, and for the phone calls, read what customers actually said in the agent's notes. We used SQL — a way of directly querying our own company databases — no outside tools, no guessing.

The old belief was wrong, in a good way: only 15.2% of removals are new customers, not 38%. Almost 4 out of 5 removals (78%) happen quietly online with no call at all. About 2 out of 3 removals, in both groups, happen close to when a bill is due. The single biggest reason for phone-call removals — 38% of them — is simply a customer's card expiring, being lost, or being replaced. The good news: 90.5% of those customers turn autopay back on within 60 days, so this isn't real churn, just a normal pause. The three reasons originally suspected (payment timing, a surprise first-bill fee, and customers disputing consent) are all real, but each is rare — well under 1% of calls.

How to Walk Through It, Slide by Slide

Assume the audience has no background on this — explain each slide as if for the first time.

Slide 1 — Title

Just introduce the topic in one sentence.

Say something like:

"This is what we found when we looked into why customers turn off autopay."

Slide 2 — Why We're Doing This

State the belief we were testing (38% new customers) and why it mattered — if new customers were the issue, the fix would be about onboarding.

Say something like:

"We wanted to check something the team believed — that new customers were driving most autopay cancellations — and find out what's really going on."

Slide 3 — How We Did This

Walk the four steps simply: pulled every removal, split by channel, read real call notes, checked timing.

Mention the tool explicitly — SQL, querying our own databases directly, nothing outside or invented.

Say something like:

"We looked at every single removal from the last 6 months, split them by how it happened, and for phone calls, read exactly what customers said."

Slide 4 — The Original Belief Was Wrong

Point at the chart: assumed 38%, actual 15.2%.

Say something like:

“The team believed 38% of removals were new customers. The real number is 15.2% — much lower.”

Slide 5 — How People Turn It Off

Point at the chart: 78% online, 22% by phone.

Say something like:

“Almost 4 out of 5 people just do this themselves online — they never call us at all.”

Slide 6 — When People Turn It Off

Point at the chart: both channels show about 2 in 3 removals near a bill due date.

Say something like:

“Whether it's a phone call or done online, about 2 out of 3 removals happen right around when a bill is due.”

Slide 7 — The #1 Reason: A Changed Payment Card

This is the biggest, most surprising finding — take your time here.

Point at the chart first (38% card-related), then the good-news box (90.5% come back within 60 days).

Make clear this is NOT a real problem — it's a normal pause, not customers giving up.

Say something like:

“The single biggest reason for a phone call is just a customer's card expiring or changing — and the good news is, 9 out of 10 of them turn autopay back on within 2 months.”

Slide 8 — Checking the Three Original Ideas

Walk the table — all three are real, but all three are rare, especially compared to the card-change finding.

Say something like:

“We also checked the three things you originally flagged — all three do happen, but each is quite rare.”

Slide 9 — Key Findings

Read the five rows as the full wrap-up of everything covered.

Say something like:

“So to put it all together — the old belief was wrong, most people don't call us at all, timing matters, the real #1 reason isn't a complaint, and the original three guesses are real but small.”

Slide 10 — Next Steps

Frame these as practical follow-ons, not more open questions.

Say something like:

“Here's what we'd suggest doing next with all of this.”

Key Findings

Finding	What We Found
New-customer removal rate	15.2% (not the assumed 38%)
How removals happen	78% online, 22% by phone
Timing	~66-70% happen within 2 weeks of the next bill due date
Biggest driver (phone calls)	38.1% are card expired/lost/replaced — 90.5% re-enroll within 60 days
Payment date timing	About 1 in 150 calls
Surprise first-bill fee	About 1 in 1,000 calls
Never agreed to autopay	About 1 in 1,000 calls

Next Steps

- **Stop worrying about new-customer churn from autopay** — the real number is much lower than assumed.
- **Consider a friendly reminder before a card expires** — could reduce a big chunk of these calls entirely.
- **Loop in the Ops team on the consent question** — rare, but still worth a quick conversation.
- **Keep an eye on timing-related removals** — small today, worth tracking if schedules change.

Questions to Ask

1.

Does the card-expiration finding change how urgent this feels, now that we know most people come back on their own?

2.

Is a proactive card-expiration reminder something worth prioritizing, given how many calls it could prevent?

3.

Should we still loop in the Ops team on the consent issue, even though it's rare, or deprioritize it given how small it is?

4.

Do you want this same approach (reading real call notes to find drivers) applied to any other call category?

If They Ask... (Quick Answers)

Q: How do you know the 90.5% re-enrollment number is right?

A: We checked, for every card-change-related removal, whether that same customer turned autopay back on within 60 days afterward, using the real enrollment records. It's a direct count, not an estimate.

Q: Why did the original 38% number turn out to be wrong?

A: That earlier number wasn't based on this same detailed check — it was a broader assumption. This is the first time we've actually pulled every real removal and checked it directly.

Q: Could the card-change finding just be a coincidence of this 6-month window?

A: It's possible behavior shifts over time, which is why we'd want to keep checking this periodically rather than treating it as a one-time answer.

Q: Why are the three original ideas so much smaller than expected?

A: They're genuinely real — we found real examples of each in the actual call notes — they're just a small share of the total compared to the card-change pattern, which we found by reading the data with fresh eyes rather than starting from assumptions.